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1 Research Statement

My work uses digital tools and methodologies to study language related to gender, sex, and sexulaity. While my formal training is in English Literature, with subfocuses in Queer Studies and the Digital Humanities (DH), I work at the intersection of the Humanities and Computer Science disciplines, on topics that span Trans studies, AI ethics, and digital scholarly editing.

Since beginning my position at the Pratt Institute School of Information in Fall 2024, I pursue a research agenda based on three main goals:

- (1) to interrogate the contradictions of present-day theorizations of gender, sex, and sexuality;
- (2) to read computational mechanisms as heuristics for cultural norms; and
- (3) to communicate across the Humanities and Computer Science disciplines.

As of Fall 2026, I have written five papers, two that have been published in peer-reviewed venues, and three that are currently being considered for publication at peer-reviewed venues. In addition, I have also secured an academic book contract, with a manuscript due in spring 2027.

In what follows, I explain the details of this work and how they fit into the goals described above.

1.0.1 To Interrogate The Contradictions Of Present-Day Theorizations Of In Gender, Sex, And Sexuality

Much of my more recent research takes contemporary discourses on gender, sex, and sexuality as its primary subject. The aim of my research is to disentangle some of the contradictions that constitute social and cultural definitions of these terms. Over the past decade, the discourse on gender in particular has been highly polarized, with various gender movements, including reactionary movements of what is called "gender-critical feminism" and

"TERFism," which are driven by conservative arguments opposing "gender ideology" by grounding definitions of gender in "biological" sex.

I explore these contradictions in two recent papers, both which are currently being considered at peer-reviewed venues.

- The first paper, "What LLMs Can't See About Gender," under review at *FAccT 2027*, argues that some gender bias evaluation methods effectively limit how LLMs may detect and mitigate gender bias. These methods, which define gender as primarily an internal phenomenon, miss the ways that gender is expressed as external or behavioral in language. Drawing from recent theorizing in Trans Studies theorizing on the subject, the paper argues that defining gender as internal only reinscribes dominant, normative gender and furthers marginalizing visibly non-normative genders.
- the paper explains that when gender is defined as internal, genders which are apparently normative will be read as "default", while non-normative genders become hyper-visible and therefore vulnerable to stigmatization.
- The second paper, "'My Body Feels Like it's Coming Off': on Cis Embodiment in *Love Is Blind*," under review at *TSQ: Trans Studies Quarterly*, draws from cisgender experiences of disembodiment to theorize common ground between trans and cis experiences of bodily dissonance. It analyzes a dating reality TV show, *Love Is Blind*, which places its cisgender participants into an environment where they cannot see their partners, which evokes aspects of bodily dissociation as theorized in Trans Studies. The paper argues that these experiences create a common ground between cis and trans relationships to their own bodies, even despite their dramatically different life experiences and identities.

1.0.2 Reading Computational Mechanism As Heuristics For Cultural Norms

This research theme is the main argument of my forthcoming book, *Queer Code: Re-working Language Technologies*, which is in contract with Bloomsbury Academic Press.

The book explores how language technologies, like web scraping, text analysis, and generative AI, reduce language complexity to make it computable. In these technologies, words are removed from their original context, cleaned and standardized, so that they can be stored and analyzed at

scale. These increasingly automated processes encode dominant logics and extractive incentives onto language data, creating well-documented issues with data sovereignty, privacy, and most recently, bias, as current AI tools demonstrate.

Each of the book's five chapters considers how these processes of reduction operate through different language technologies, identifying a mechanism in each technology that reduces or flattens language meaning. Then, drawing from Queer Studies and related fields, the book identifies conceptual tools that re-work these constraints into new analytical methodologies to open up novel readings of language data.

The table below outlines the technology, constraint, and conceptual tool across each of the book's five chapters.

Chapter	Technology	Mechanism	Concept
1. Text Capture	Web Scraping	Protocol	Reparative Reading ¹
2. Text Analysis	Text Analysis	Iteration	Gender Performativity ²
3. Text Preservation	Markup Languages	Containment	Dis-Identification ³
4. Text Display	Screen Display	Abstraction	The Flesh ⁴
5. Text Generation	Machine Learning	Aggregation	Body Dysphoria ⁵

For example, chapter 2, "Text Analysis," explores the technology of *text analysis* and its mechanism of *iteration*: a programmatic logic of repetition in which text analysis programs execute the same action across large collections of text, one word at a time, with the attendant effect of suppressing minor details in language forms in favor of more frequent textual patterns. The chapter then takes Judith Butler's concept of *Gender Performativity* as a conceptual tool to re-work iteration into a new text analysis practice for studying gender in language.

1.0.3 Communicating Across The Disciplines

In my research, disciplinary boundary-crossing aims to engage knowledges that otherwise may not come into contact with one another. Over the past two years, I have written three papers for primarily Computer Science (CS)

¹Sedgwick, "Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading." *Touching Feeling*.

²Butler, Judith. *Bodies that Matter*.

³Muñoz, Jose Esteban. *Disidentifications*.

⁴Spillers, Hortense. "Mama's Baby, Papa's Maybe".

⁵Prosser, Jay. *Second Skins*.

fields like Computational Linguistics and AI Ethics. I have written two papers for the Humanities fields of Trans studies and digital scholarly editing.

My CS papers include the aforementioned "What LLMs Can't See About Gender," under review at *FAccT 2027*, as well as two other papers: "Some Myths About Bias: A Queer Studies Reading Of Gender Bias In NLP," published in the *Association for Computational Linguistics 2025 Proceedings*, and "Small Language Models and the Synthetic Middle," under review at *NeurIPS 2026*. These papers draw from theorizing in Queer studies and Trans studies in order to make recommendations to CS fields. "Some Myths About Bias" draws from Queer Studies theorizing on the binary to argue that bias is embedded in language in ways that require more careful handling to avoid falling into the trap of binary thinking. The other paper, "Small Language Models and the Synthetic Middle," incorporate close reading into a novel, interdisciplinary methodology to study overlap (the "synthetic middle") between polarized discourses on gender and transgender rights in the USA.

My Humanities work includes the aforementioned paper in Trans studies, "'My Body Feels Like it's Coming Off': on Cis Embodiment in *Love Is Blind*," and another in the field of digital scholarly editing, "Re-encoding Dominance: Queer Approaches To TEI Markup," published in *Digital Editing & Publishing in the 21st Century*. This paper examines how a language technology, TEI (Text Encoding Initiative), a markup standard for encoding text-based cultural heritage materials, might be read alongside theories from Queer studies and historical work on the archive of slavery.